

# Fragrance, hands, and the details that signal care

Week 8 Lecture 2 , Looksmaxxing

Autumn 2026

## What we'll cover

- The anatomy of a fragrance: top, heart, and base notes
- Fragrance families and which contexts each fits
- A starter kit that does not overcomplicate things
- Nail and cuticle care as a visible signal
- Hand cream: when and how much
- Body odor and antiperspirant: mechanism and timing

# How fragrance works

# Three layers in time

A fragrance is not a single smell. It changes on your skin over hours because different molecules evaporate at different rates.

- **Top notes (0-30 min):** volatile citrus and fresh notes; what you smell in the bottle
- **Heart notes (30 min to 2 hours):** the actual character of the fragrance; the note family that defines it
- **Base notes (2-8 hours):** fixatives and depth; what others smell when you have been wearing it all day

The practical consequence: never judge a fragrance from the bottle or from a 30-second spray on your wrist at a counter. Wear it for an hour and then evaluate.

Source: Curly Fragrance, 2025 , "Heart notes are what the fragrance actually smells like on your skin after 30 minutes; base notes are what others smell when you've been wearing it all day."

## Projection vs sillage

- **Projection:** how far the scent radiates from your body
- **Sillage (see-YAH):** the trail you leave when you walk through a room
- Both are controlled by fragrance concentration and application amount
- Eau de toilette has lower concentration (5-15%) and lighter projection than eau de parfum (15-20%)
- For most daily wear, lighter projection is the right target: people should notice when they are close, not when you enter the room

# Fragrance families

## Four families and their contexts

| Family   | Character                  | Context                          |
|----------|----------------------------|----------------------------------|
| Fresh    | Citrus, aquatic, green     | Morning, work, outdoor           |
| Woody    | Cedar, sandalwood, vetiver | Casual evening, autumn, office   |
| Oriental | Amber, vanilla, spice      | Evening, cold weather, going out |
| Floral   | Rose, jasmine, iris        | Spring, light daytime wear       |

Most men's starter fragrances sit in fresh or woody families. Oriental fragrances project more and wear longer: use them when you want the scent to be noticed, not just present.

## The starter kit: two fragrances

More is not better. A two-fragrance kit covers all situations without requiring decision overhead.

- **One fresh daytime:** citrus or aquatic top notes, light projection, suitable for work and errands. Wear this most days.
- **One warm evening:** woody or light oriental base, heavier projection, for dates and social settings.

That is the whole kit. Do not buy a third bottle until you have worn both of these at least twenty times each and understand how they behave on your skin.



## How to sample before buying

- Fragrance counters will spray on a strip; ask them to spray on your wrist instead
- Come back in 45 minutes after doing other errands and evaluate the heart note on your skin
- Fragrance decants (small vials of 2-5 ml) exist for most major releases and cost a few dollars each: use them to wear a fragrance for a full day before committing to a bottle
- A 50 ml bottle lasts one to two years with daily use; there is no urgency to buy large

## Application: how much and where

- Two to four sprays for most fragrances on most days
- Pulse points: neck, wrists, chest. Heat amplifies diffusion.
- Do not rub your wrists together after spraying: it crushes the top-note molecules and shortens the progression
- Do not spray on clothes if you can avoid it: fragrance interacts with skin chemistry, and some oils stain fabric
- For daily fresh fragrances, less is more. For evening orientals, the same rule applies.

# Hands and nails

# Why hands are a cheap visible signal

Hands are one of the first things people notice in conversation, on a first date, and in a job interview. They are also one of the easiest parts of your appearance to improve in under five minutes per week.

The checklist:

- Nails trimmed straight across with a small white edge remaining
- Cuticles not dry, cracked, or peeling
- Skin on the back of the hand not visibly dry or rough
- No hangnails

None of these require a manicure. All of them require a nail clipper, a nail file, and some hand cream.

## Nail and cuticle care protocol

1. **Trim** nails straight across using nail clippers. Do not cut below the free edge of the nail.
2. **File** rough edges with an emery board to prevent snagging.
3. **Soften cuticles** by applying a small amount of cuticle oil or hand cream and pushing them back gently with a cuticle pusher or the edge of a towel. Do not cut cuticles: cut cuticles bleed, get infected, and look worse.
4. **Moisturize** the whole hand after trimming.

Frequency: trim every 7-10 days. File and moisturize as needed.

## Hand cream: when and how much

- Apply hand cream after washing your hands, especially in winter when detergents strip the skin barrier
- A pea-sized amount for both hands is sufficient
- Work it into the backs of the hands, knuckles, and finger joints, not just the palms
- Any basic unscented moisturizer works: this does not need to be a specialty product
- Men with dry or cracked hands benefit from applying a slightly thicker cream at night and sleeping in it occasionally

# Body odor and antiperspirant

## Deodorant vs antiperspirant: different jobs

- **Deodorant:** masks odor by fragrance or kills odor-causing bacteria. Does not stop sweating.
- **Antiperspirant:** contains aluminum salts that physically block sweat ducts. Reduces wetness and therefore odor.
- If you are using deodorant alone and noticing odor, you are using the wrong product for the job.

Most men benefit from an antiperspirant, not a deodorant. The two are often sold in the same aisle and the word “deodorant” appears on both: read the active ingredient. Aluminum zirconium tetrachlorohydrex is an antiperspirant active.



## When and how to apply antiperspirant

- Apply to **dry skin**, ideally at night before bed, not immediately after a shower in the morning
- Nighttime application works because sweat ducts are less active while you sleep, so the aluminum salts have time to form the temporary plug before you sweat
- Morning showers do not wash off an overnight application completely: the aluminum salt is already in the duct
- If standard strength is not holding, clinical-strength formulations (20%+ aluminum concentration) are available over the counter and are the correct next step before seeing a doctor

## Body odor basics

- The primary source of underarm odor is bacterial metabolism of apocrine sweat: bacteria break down secretions into odor compounds
- Showering removes bacteria; antiperspirant reduces the substrate (sweat) they feed on
- Non-underarm odor (feet, groin) is the same mechanism: bacteria on skin metabolizing secretions
- Moisture-wicking fabrics and cotton underwear reduce the bacterial load in high-sweat areas
- Diet affects body odor: garlic, red meat, and alcohol are documented contributors

## Take-aways

1. Evaluate fragrance on your skin after 30-45 minutes, not from the bottle: heart notes are the character, base notes are the staying power.
2. A two-fragrance starter kit (one fresh daytime, one warm evening) covers everything.
3. Hands and nails are a visible signal that takes five minutes per week to maintain.
4. Antiperspirant works by blocking sweat ducts; apply it to dry skin at night for best effect.
5. Clinical-strength antiperspirant is the over-the-counter option before escalating to a dermatologist for hyperhidrosis.

"Top notes are what you smell in the bottle; heart notes are what the fragrance actually smells like on your skin after 30 minutes; base notes are what others smell when you've been wearing it all day."

Curly Fragrance YouTube channel (2025)

## What's next

- **Section (this week):** Grooming kit show-and-tell. Bring all tools, get feedback, list three swaps.
- **Reading:** Beard, brows, fragrance, hands , required before section.
- **Week 9:** Posture, gait, and presenting yourself in photos.
- **HW 3 (Strength program and nutrition plan):** Due this week.